

Spatial Storytelling Platform

A discussion one-pager · Draft for conversation

A community-led platform for spatial heritage preservation: 3D scans of places, oral narratives, photos, documents, and stories — uploaded by the people who live with that heritage, viewable in browser and VR. Independent of hardware vendors like Matterport or Scaniverse. Open source, open workflow, open to anyone.

FIVE QUESTIONS TO SHAPE THE PLATFORM

1. What can be uploaded?

- 3D spatial scans of environments
- 3D scans of objects
- Photos of objects and places
- Oral micro-narratives (audio)
- **Video** — walkthroughs, interviews, demonstrations of practice
- Site maps and floor plans
- Written stories and narratives
- Historical documents

2. Who can contribute, and how?

- Residents and stakeholders of the place
- Journalists, architects, researchers documenting the place
- Open to anyone, verified contributors only, or a hybrid?
- How is moderation handled — community-led, curated, or both?

3. Who controls what's shared?

This is the area that needs the most thinking. A simple open / private toggle isn't enough.

- Granular access tiers: public, community-only, time-limited, contributor-only
- Right to withdraw a contribution after upload
- Sensitive content handling — sacred sites, contested histories, living people
- Clear licensing per item (Creative Commons options)
- Consider the **CARE Principles** (Collective benefit, Authority to control, Responsibility, Ethics) as a frame — they go beyond "open vs private" to ask who has authority over the material

4. How is it experienced?

- Browser-first — most people won't have a headset
- VR headset support via WebXR

- Hotspots in 3D scans trigger audio, video, image, or text
- **Authoring tool for non-technical contributors** — placing hotspots, linking media, writing captions, without needing a developer
- Multi-language support
- Accessibility — captions, transcripts, alt text

5. How does it stay alive?

- Open file formats so contributors can take their data out (glTF, USDZ, OGG, etc.)
- Open source code, open API
- Hosting model — nonprofit, institutional partner, federated, or self-hostable?
- Funding for storage and maintenance beyond year one
- Metadata standards so the archive is still usable in ten years (Dublin Core, PBCore, or similar — light-touch for users, structured underneath)

Prototype scope

A 3D-scanned environment with audio, video, and image narratives triggered at hotspots. Works in browser and on a VR headset. One real site, one community of contributors, end-to-end.

Why this matters. Commercial 3D capture platforms lock heritage data into proprietary viewers and pricing tiers. Institutional archives often exclude the people whose heritage is being preserved. Community projects like Scan the World, the Geelong Digital Outdoor Museum, and Santa Clara 3D each solve one slice of the problem. A unified, community-led, open platform doesn't yet exist.